

The Rise of the Telegraph

Before the nineteenth century, communication could travel only as fast as a messenger on horseback or a ship at sea. News, orders, and personal letters often took weeks or months to reach their destinations. That changed dramatically with the invention of the telegraph. Using electric signals sent through wires, people could transmit messages across vast distances in seconds, transforming both business and daily life. The first major network was developed in the 1840s by Samuel Morse in the United States. His system converted words into patterns of short and long electrical pulses, known as Morse code. Telegraph offices soon lined railroad stations, allowing traders to track prices and newspapers to report events almost as they happened. During the American Civil War, generals used the telegraph to coordinate troop movements, demonstrating how information could become as decisive as weaponry. Similar systems spread across Europe and later under the oceans, connecting continents through submarine cables. The telegraph compressed the world. It reshaped politics, commerce, and journalism by introducing the idea of instant communication. Though later replaced by telephones and the internet, the telegraph laid the first electronic foundation for the global networks that now link nearly every part of human society.

Questões

1. All of the following are mentioned in the passage as effects of the telegraph EXCEPT —

- a. The spread of international communication
- b. Quicker reporting of news events
- c. Improvements in transportation speed
- d. Changes in political and commercial life

2. The word “compressed” in the passage is closest in meaning to

- a. weakened
- b. shortened
- c. expanded

d. delayed

3. Why does the author mention Samuel Morse?

- a. To identify the inventor who developed the first large-scale telegraph network
- b. To compare his invention with earlier systems of long-distance communication
- c. To show how his work improved military technology
- d. To explain why his code was later replaced by the telephone

4. What can be inferred about communication before the telegraph?

- a. It involved widespread use of coded signals.
- b. It was faster but less reliable than later systems.
- c. It relied entirely on transportation speed to deliver messages.
- d. It required coordination between countries through trade networks.

5. What is the relationship between paragraphs 2 and 3?

- a. Paragraph 3 provides detailed examples of how Morse's code was transmitted.
- b. Paragraph 3 contrasts the telegraph with newer communication inventions.
- c. Paragraph 3 introduces problems caused by the telegraph's invention.
- d. Paragraph 3 explains the broader impact of the developments described in paragraph 2.